

THE HOLD-UP

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

HOLD-UP LESSON

The hold-up play is one of the first techniques bridge players learn, right up there with finessing. And the first example they are shown will be something like this one.

You are playing a notrump contract.

Your Left Hand Opponent leads the ♥5 and RHO puts on the ♥Q.

Here is the ♥ suit in dummy's and your hands.

Dummy ♥ 8 4

You ♥ A 10 2

Suppose you take your ♥A at the first (or second) trick. Then, whenever you lose a trick to either opponent they will win some ♥ tricks, four of them if LHO has led a 5-card suit.

But suppose you refuse to win your ♥A until the third round; you hold-up. Then, whenever you lose a trick to your RHO he may be void in ♥s because he started out with just three of them. Since he cannot lead a ♥ back to his partner your contract may be successful.

Of course, even after the hold-up, if you lose a later trick to your LHO he will then cash his ♥ tricks. So hold-up plays aren't always perfect solutions.

The Basic Hold-up:

Look at that ♥ suit in a full example.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5. East plays ♥Q.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ 5 4 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ A 10 2
♦ Q 6 3
♣ A K 10 6

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 5.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.

The danger is that West may hold five ♥s, so when you drive out the ♦A, the defense may be able to win 4 ♥ tricks to go along with their 1 ♦.

So you hold-up your ♥A until the third round. Then you play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes the ♦A. If it is East who wins, and he started with only 3 ♥s, he will have none to return to his partner's hand. And if East does happen to have a fourth ♥ it means the ♥ suit was originally 4-4 and you will only lose 3 tricks in the suit..

Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.
East plays the ♥A and returns the ♥9.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 6.

You need 3 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.
Once East takes the ♥A on the first round the situation becomes identical to the first example.
You hold-up your ♥K until the third round. Then you drive out the ♦A and hope it is East who has it.

Not Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5.
East plays the ♥J.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ A J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 ? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

The opening lead guarantees you a ♥ trick.
And you'd better take it right now or East will return a ♥ and West will take all the ♥ winners he happened to be dealt.

This was not a time to hold up, and after you win the first trick you pin all your hopes on the ♦ finesse. If West holds the ♦K you will make the contract. If East holds the ♦K they are going to bury you with ♥s.

Holding Up with A J x: or not:

When your LHO leads a suit in which you hold A J x and RHO plays a high honor, you have an interesting situation. This holding might be just one stopper, but might be two, depending on which defender will be getting the lead.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will take his ♠ winners.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will not be able to lead ♠s without setting up your ♠J.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will lead a ♠ through your ♠J 2 and West will win a lot of ♠s.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will be unable to return a ♠ to his partner (unless they split 4-4).

Holding Up with Two Stoppers:

If you have to establish a suit which is missing two top honors then you may have to hold-up on their suit when you have it double-stopped.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♦J.
East plays the ♦K.

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ A 7 3
♥ A 8 3
♦ 6 5 2
♣ J 10 9 6

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 : Total = 7.

You need to get 2 tricks from ♣s. The danger is that West may have a 5-card ♦ suit that can be established before you can set up any ♠ tricks.

Suppose you take your ♦A at trick one and play on ♣s. If the two high ♣s are split, East will win the first ♣ and play another ♦, allowing West to establish the suit. When you again play ♣s, WEST will take his winner and also take some ♦s.

Suppose you allow East to win the ♦K. He will return the suit and drive out one of your stoppers, but he will use his last remaining ♦ to do so. Now, whenever East takes his ♣ winner he will have no ♦s to help West establish the suit. Since West has only one entry in ♣s he can win it and establish the ♦s, but won't be able to get back in to cash them.


♠ K Q 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ A Q 3
♣ Q 7 5 4

Holding Up at a Suit Contract:

The hold-up is utilized most often when you are playing notrump; the purpose usually being to disrupt communications between the defenders by exhausting one defender of his partner's suit. This use of a hold-up doesn't really apply to suit contracts.

There are other reasons for a hold-up, though, which do apply in suit contracts.

The contract is 4♥ and West's opening lead is the ♠3.
East plays the ♠Q.

Since this is a suit contract count your losers.

♠ 8 7
♥ Q 10 8 3
♦ K 7 5
♣ A J 9 4

♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

You can't avoid losing 1 ♠, and the ♦A is also a sure loser. If the ♣ finesse works you would be home free, but even if it fails you can guarantee the contract with a hold-up play.

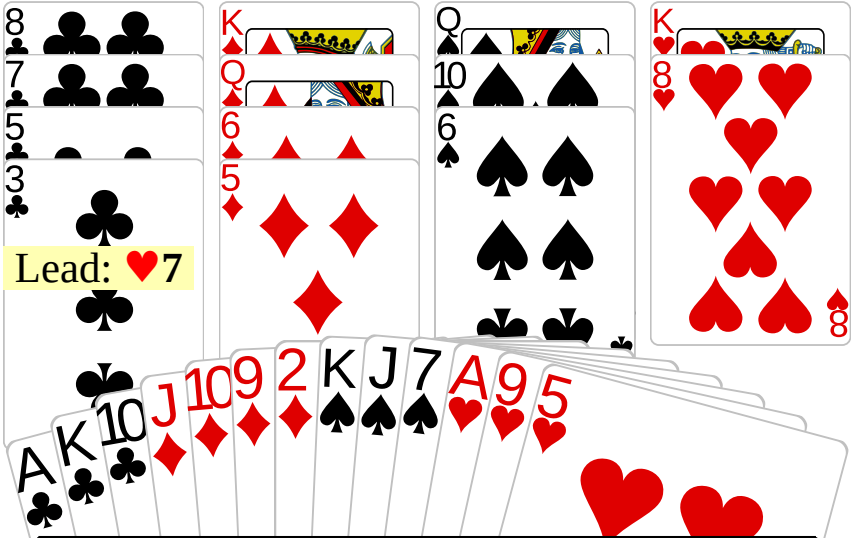
The danger is that if East holds the ♦A, West may obtain the lead and play a ♦ through dummy's ♦K, giving you two ♦ losers. You can prevent that from happening if you can prevent West from getting the lead. Since the only suit West can get the lead with is ♠s, all you have to do is let East win the ♠Q and take your ♠A on the second round.


♠ A 6 2
♥ A K J 6 2
♦ 8 6
♣ Q 10 3

Since East cannot attack ♦s from his side he will have to give you the lead. You pull trumps, then finesse the ♣. Even if the finesse loses East cannot play ♦s without setting up dummy's ♦K, so you will eventually get to discard one of your ♦ losers on dummy's fourth ♣.

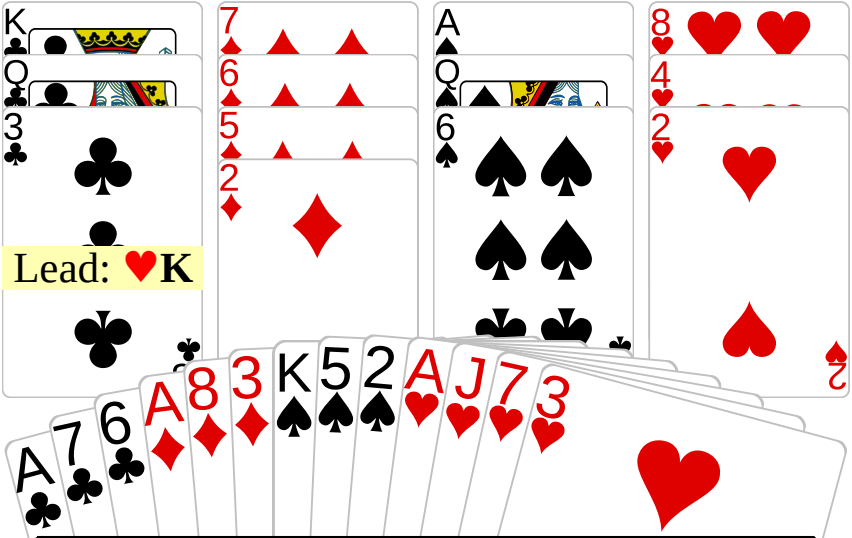
15 Practice Deals will be worth more than another 1500 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

A

Q

9

7

4

Lead: ♥ J

Q

10

5

9

6

2

Q

5

K

J

8

6

A

J

8

Q

8

4

A

7

2

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

7

5

4

2

♣

Lead: ♥ 6

K

J

10

3

Q

7

4

8

5

K

J

6

A

Q

6

5

A

K

5

A

7

2

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥7

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♥K

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♥J

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♥6

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ A 8 3

♥ Q J 10 6 4 2

♦ 7 3

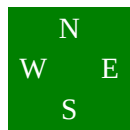
♣ 4 2

♠ K J 7

♥ A 9 5

♦ J 10 9 2

♣ A K 10



♠ Q 10 6

♥ K 8

♦ K Q 6 5

♣ 8 7 5 3

♠ 9 5 4 2

♥ 7 3

♦ A 8 4

♣ Q J 9 6

West

2♥

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥7

North

2NT

East

Pass

South

3NT

North's 2NT overcall shows a 1NT opening hand with ♥s stopped. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥7.

West plays the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 4

You will need to establish both ♠ and ♦ winners. If West holds both these Aces along with 6 ♥s to the Q J then you are going down. But of course West can't have that good a hand, he opened with a Weak-2. So East has one of the Aces.

If you knew which Ace West held you could make sure you attacked that suit first but unfortunately you have no way of knowing that. So instead you resort to a hold-up.

West continues with the ♥Q.

East follows with the ♥3.

You let West have the first ♥ and won the next ♥ in dummy.

Start on ♦s next, maybe because they are longer. Assume that East holds the ♦A and takes it on the third round of the suit.

East glares at you, (because he has no ♥ to lead), and plays the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A. Next you score your ♦ winners and play a ♠, taken by West with the ♠A.

West glares at you, (because you still have the ♥A), and plays another ♥.

You take your 3 tricks and let East have the last ♣.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♦s first you would not have made the contract.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♠s first you would have made the contract even though you played incorrectly.

If you held up on the first trick you made the contract no matter which Ace East held.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A Q 6
♥ 8 4 2
♦ 7 6 5 2
♣ K Q 3

♠ J 10 8 7
♥ 6
♦ K J 10 9
♣ J 9 8 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 5 2
♥ A J 7 3
♦ A 8 3
♣ A 7 6

♠ 9 4 3
♥ K Q 10 9 5
♦ Q 4
♣ 10 5 2

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
		1NT	Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♥K

continue, just what you want.

Sometimes it works, sometimes it doesn't.

I sure hope that when you play this hand South falls for your Bath Coup.

Because if he doesn't you're going to have to end-play him.

Do you see how that might happen?

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and North the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You just need one more winner and it could come from the ♦ suit if it happens to split 3-3. But you have another possibility. Suppose you let South hold the first trick and he decides to play another ♥? You would have two ♥ winners.

This isn't a true hold-up play although it does look like one. This play has the rather fancy name of Bath Coup, (named from Bath, England). Presumably South has led from ♥ K Q 10 9 5 and North has played his singleton ♥6. If South realizes that North has played his lowest card he will take that as a discouraging signal and will play a different suit. So you throw out your ♥7 rather than the ♥3. Now South may think that North is encouraging him to

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A K J 5
 ♥ J 10 9 8
 ♦ 9 6 4
 ♣ 10 3

♠ 9 6 2

♥ Q 5

♦ Q 10 5

♣ A Q 9 7 4



♠ 10 7 3

♥ K 6 4 3

♦ K 7 3 2

♣ 5 2

♠ Q 8 4

♥ A 7 2

♦ A J 8

♣ K J 8 6

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		1NT

3NT by South

Lead: ♥J

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥J. You try dummy's ♥Q but East plays the ♥K.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=5 Total = 7

Things do not look good. You have only one ♥ stopper, the ♠ suit is wide open, and you have to have the ♦ finesse to get the two extra winners you need.

First problem: Do you hold up the ♥A or not?

No, don't hold up. If you do they might take 4 ♠ tricks immediately, then go back to ♥s. Since your only hope of making this contract is the ♦ finesse you should grab the ♥A, play 5 rounds of ♣s then finesse for the ♦K.

Or not.

Remember: don't hold up when it gives the defenders a good opportunity to switch.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A K 5
 ♥ A 7 2
 ♦ A Q 6 5
 ♣ K J 6

♠ 9 6 3
 ♥ K J 9 6 3
 ♦ 8 4 2
 ♣ Q 9

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q 7 4
 ♥ 8 5
 ♦ K J 10 3
 ♣ 7 5 4 2

♠ J 10 8 2
 ♥ Q 10 4
 ♦ 9 7
 ♣ A 10 8 3

West	North	East	South
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			
3NT by West			
Lead: ♥6			

plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when South plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

This is not a guess. If North has the ♣A he will get the lead and when he does he will set you with 2 more ♥ tricks. So you assume that South has the ♣A and play your ♣K.

This is a lesson about holding up, and if you had not held up twice in ♥s you would certainly have gone down.

But it's not enough to just be smart enough to hold up, you must also be able to figure out how to make the best plays later as well.

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥5 and South the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=4 ♣=0 Total = 8

You need only one more winner.

South returns the ♥10.

North wins with the ♥J and continues with the ♥3; dummy discards a ♣ and South plays the ♥4.

Needing only one more winner, you held up on the first ♥ and on the continuation, taking your ♥A on the third round.

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when South